

## Rough Weather OR Poor Terrain

Battles in well-lit open fields are difficult and dangerous enough, but battles outdoors in the midst of a sub-zero blizzard or inside a burning warehouse are even more so. If characters are fighting in difficult terrain or weather conditions, including in heavy rain or billowing smoke, with ice or jagged rocks underfoot, or while standing on shifting and baking-hot sand dunes, all combat rolls increase their difficulty by +1 to +3, depending on just how extreme and unpleasant the environmental conditions are. Fighting in smoke, while standing in shallow water, or on shifting sand might increase difficulties by +1; add in extreme temperatures, heavy rain, or a swift current in the water and difficulties increase further. More extreme conditions can also be threats in their own right, see the Sources of Injury section (p. 291) for details.

provide your character with a chance to avoid almost any attack, but each one has different advantages and disadvantages. Regardless of which of these three maneuvers your character chooses, the basic mechanics of rolling for defense are identical.

Make a resisted roll against the character's opponent's attack roll. If the attacker fails to roll more successes than the defender, the defender has successfully avoided or deflected the attack. If the attacker achieves more successes than the defender, then the attack hits. However, the attacker subtracts the defender's successes from the number of successes she achieved with her attack roll and applies any remaining successes to the attack. Even if a defensive maneuver doesn't prevent an attack, it is almost certain to weaken the blow. Unless stated otherwise, all defense rolls are made at difficulty 6.

## Defensive Maneuvers

**Blocking:** You character uses her own body, usually her arms, to block the attack. Block rolls are made using Dexterity + Brawl. Normally, blocks only work against attacks that do bashing damage — blocking a sword blow with your arm just changes where the sword hits you. However, wearing armor allows a character to block attacks that do lethal or aggravated damage. Blocking cannot be used to defend against firearms. Blocking any ranged attacks by bows, crossbows, or thrown weapons increases the difficulty of the block roll by 2.

**Dodging:** Dodging is nothing more than moving out of the way of a blow and includes everything from a graceful evasion to falling to the ground and hoping not to get hit. Dodge rolls use Dexterity + Athletics. Dodging works against all types of attacks, but requires that the character have sufficient room to maneuver. Often, the most effective form of dodging a ranged weapon is moving behind cover (see cover, p. 280). The difficulty of dodging attacks by bows or crossbows is 8, while the difficulty of dodging thrown weapons is only 6. Dodging firearms

attacks is possible, but the roll is made at difficulty 9. This difficulty increases to 10 for attempts to dodge shotgun attacks, automatic fire, strafing, or three-round bursts.

**Parrying:** Characters parry by using a weapon they are wielding to block or deflect the weapon attacking them and the roll is Dexterity + Melee. Parrying cannot be used to defend against firearms. Parrying ranged attacks by bows, crossbows, or thrown weapons increases the difficulty of the parry roll by 2, but sufficiently-skilled characters can deflect or even cut arrows with their blades. When parrying an unarmed attack, the defender may harm the attacker — having your fist blocked by a mace or a sword hurts. If the defender rolls more successes than the attacker, the defender reflexively rolls the weapon's base damage plus the parry's extra successes as a damage dice pool against the attacker. This type of attack via parrying does not cost the defender an extra action and is called a rebound attack.

**Normal Defense vs. Desperate Defense:** Your character can perform blocks, dodges, and parries as part of multiple actions. This choice allows your character to swing her sword to both attack and then parry, or to shoot a gun and then dive for cover. This tactic allows you to both attack and defend, although obviously not as well as if your character performed only one of these actions. Choosing to have your character only defend during a turn is called a *desperate defense* and allows her to defend against multiple attacks. Instead of using the normal rules for multiple actions, your character's first defensive roll in a turn is made at no penalty, and each successive defense against a different attack subtracts one die from the roll, until your character has no more dice to subtract or no more attacks to defend against. However, defending against multiple opponents causes your character to suffer the normal difficulty penalties for facing multiple opponents (see multiple opponents, p. 278).

## Phase Four: Resolution and Damage

Once all the characters have determined if their attacks hit or missed, the next step is to see how much damage the characters inflicted or suffered. The resolution of damage should be more than the Storyteller or a player saying that their character inflicted three health levels of lethal damage on their foe. There should also be an element of storytelling and roleplaying, "Your arrow pierced the hellsteed's leg, causing it to stumble and utter a hideous shriek" or "the angry troll punches you with a huge, calloused fist; even through your chainmail hauberk, you can feel your ribs crack." Remembering to combine both story and mechanics makes the game a lot more exciting for everyone.

Rolling damage is relatively simple. Every weapon, from a fist to an assault rifle, has a base damage. The attacker rolls this base damage + one additional die for every success after the first on a character's attack roll. If a character fires a bow and the player rolls four successes on her attack roll, she adds three dice to the damage roll. It's also important to know if a weapon does bashing, lethal or (on rare occasions) aggravated damage. Every weapon's base damage and damage type, as well as its range (for ranged weapons) are included on the Close